provided some advice. But critically this advice was not followed, and it was a one-off'.

It is beyond the scope of this book to ascertain how much defence equipment the UK was able to sell to India or for that matter the kind of economic or diplomatic advantage some similarly placed Western countries might have taken of India in view of this self-created problem of India's. However, Margaret Thatcher was able to persuade Rajiv Gandhi to buy twenty-one Westland-30 helicopters for 65 million pounds, under a UK grant-in-aid scheme. [6]

Thatcher's foreign secretary, Sir Geoffrey Howe, wanted the Scotland Yard to ban protests planned by British Sikh groups, including the 'Republic of Khalistan', because a 'Sikh march in present circumstances would carry very serious risk, both for Indo-British relations and law and order in this country'. British High Commissioner to India Robert Wade Grey informed the foreign office that the celebrations by British Sikhs in the UK following Indira Gandhi's assassination could have a direct impact on this deal. Geoffrey Howe's private secretary, Leonard Appleyard, was more specific when he sent a note to the home office, saying, 'Contracts which would be potentially at risk from a trade boycott amount to some 5 billion pounds.'

Finally, India bought twenty-one of the Westland helicopters, which were inducted into the Pawan Hans fleet in 1986, to fly from Mumbai to offshore oil rigs and to ferry pilgrims to the Vaishno Devi shrine from Jammu. Two of these helicopters (nicknamed 'flying coffins') crashed, one in 1988 in Jammu and one in 1989 in Nagaland, killing ten. The troubled fleet was grounded soon after, following endless wrangling over their obvious design flaws. [7]

'Snatch and grab'

Taking a lead from these revelations in the British press, an investigative report by journalist Sandeep Unnithan appeared in *India Today* in its issue of 31 January 2014. It said a 'snatch and grab' heliborne top-secret operation codenamed 'Operation Sundown', to grab and whisk away Bhindranwale from his Guru